

How Requests Create Reasons

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Abstract

By issuing requests of one another, we wield what is, on reflection, a remarkable power: to create reasons at will. But how can requesters give us reasons to do what they want, even when they stand in no relation of authority over us? And what would be lost if we saw requests as communicating the existence of pre-existing reasons, rather than creating new ones?

I propose that a request creates a reason when and because treating such requests as reasons would help the addressee to comply better with their duties. I show that this view explains how requests create reasons, why requesting is valuable, and how the reasons created by requests depend on antecedent considerations. I argue, further, that this view clarifies the discretionary nature of the reasons created by requests, gives a unified account of how requests create reasons among intimates and strangers, and reveals important forms of unfairness that result from requests.

Introduction

You are not required to stop and aid every stranger you encounter. Seeing a lost tourist, you can permissibly decide not to help, thinking to yourself, “I’ll help the next time I see someone in their shoes.” But this thought rings hollow when the lost stranger *requests* your help. Your normative situation has changed. You must now cite a reason for not helping or else provide assistance. Requesters wield what is, on reflection, a remarkable power: to create reasons at will.

This power is puzzling. How can requesters just *decide* to create reasons, which depend not only on the content of the request, but on the simple fact that a request was made? Promises and commands raise similar questions, but requests are especially striking, because—unlike promises—they exercise unilateral control over *the addressee’s* reasons and—unlike commands—requests exercise this control without invoking any relation of authority that would justify it. The power to create reasons by uttering a few special words is, as Hume says, “one of the most mysterious and incomprehensible operations that can possibly be imagin’d.” (1739, 3.2.5.14)

But what value would be lost if we saw requests as devices for communicating the existence of pre-existing reasons, rather than creating new ones? After all, we are often put off by requests from those who lack good independent reasons for making them (Gläser, 2019, pp. 36, 39–42), and such requests often fail to create reasons—imagine someone asking that you commit murder, or that you fly abroad to retrieve a toothbrush they forgot on vacation. Such cases suggest that our reasons to grant requests are explained, at least in part, by independent considerations. What is the point of requesting, beyond reminding the addressee of these considerations? In addition to a basic question about how requests create reasons, we face related questions about why requesting is valuable, and how the reasons created by requests depend on considerations that are already in play.

To answer these questions, I begin with a prominent line of thought, on which requesters exercise a *normative power*: an ability to control a normative condition at will (Khokhar, 2022; Lewis, 2018; Owens, 2012; Raz, 2022; Schaber, 2021). On this view, we have reasons to grant requests because doing so realizes the value of the requester’s control over our normative circumstances. This value belongs to the practice of requesting *generally*, and only derivatively to particular requests, which explains why requests *as such* generate reasons (Raz, 2022, pp. 167–8, 172).

The challenge in pulling off this view is to identify a value that can explain both how requests create reasons *and* how these reasons depend on antecedent considerations. I argue that requests are valuable because they improve compliance with *imperfect duties*—duties that grant us significant discretion to decide how to comply. Take our imperfect duty of mutual aid, which grants each of us some discretion to decide exactly when and how we help others. Practically any time we come across a stranger in need of assistance, we can think to ourselves that we will help next time. We are correspondingly liable to fall short of our imperfect duty of mutual aid, by repeatedly citing our discretion to defer compliance. It is valuable for you to accept that the lost stranger’s request provides you with a reason, because doing so improves your compliance with your imperfect duty.

Faced with this reason, you can no longer cite your generic interest in discretion, but must now cite a reason for not helping or else provide assistance. Requests improve compliance with imperfect duties of mutual aid, just as religious and other taxes improve compliance with imperfect duties of charity, by establishing regular times and recipients for donations (Buchanan, 1987, pp. 569-70, Scheffler, 2010, pp. 292-4).

Generalizing from this example, I propose the *Imperfect Duty Account*: a request creates a reason when and because (1) the requestee is under an imperfect duty to perform acts of the kind requested, and (2) treating such requests as reasons would be valuable, since the requestee would thereby comply better with this duty. So, on my view, a request that a person commit murder does not create a reason, because we have no imperfect duties to commit murder. More generally, requests create reasons by exercising a normative power, and this power is justified by the value of improved compliance with imperfect duties, so these duties must be in place for requests to create reasons. In this way, my view explains at once how requests create new reasons, why requesting is valuable, and how the reasons created by requests depend on antecedent considerations.

My view has several additional selling points. I will argue that it helps to explain the sense in which the reasons created by requests are discretionary, gives a unified account of how requests create reasons among intimates and strangers, and reveals important forms of unfairness that result from requests. Further, my view leads to an illuminating contrast with Raz's (1988) influential view of commands. On Raz's view, a command creates a duty when and because compliance with such commands improves the addressee's responsiveness to the reasons that apply to them already. Whereas commands create duties by summarizing antecedent reasons, requests create reasons by specifying antecedent duties.

1 The Imperfect Duty Account

A normative power is an ability to control a normative condition at will. To illustrate, suppose I ask for your help, and you comply because you know an onlooker will think highly of you (Enoch, 2011, pp. 14-5). Although you act on a reason created by my request, this reason depends not directly on my will, but on the onlooker's esteem. I adopt the widespread view that requests create reasons *at will* only when they communicate and execute a certain intention, for example an intention to hereby create a reason (Owens 2012, p. 1); to give the requestee a reason which depends on their recognition of this intention (Raz, 1975, p. 103; Enoch, 2011, p. 15; Enoch, 2014; Lewis, 2018, p. 10); or to motivate the addressee to do the act in question (Hanser 2015, p. 102; McMyler 2017, p. 79; though see Frick and Viehoff 2023, pp. 945-7).

I propose that requests exercise a normative power by serving the value of improved compliance with imperfect duties. According to the *Imperfect Duty Account*, a request creates a reason when and because:

- (1) the requestee has an imperfect duty to perform the kind of act requested, and the requester is a potential beneficiary of this duty, whose interests partly explain why the duty is owed; and
- (2a) treating such requests as reasons would improve the requestee's compliance with this duty, while
- (2b) granting the requester control over their dependence on others and associated reasons of reciprocity.

The power to create reasons by requesting is valuable for both parties involved.¹ The main value is for requesters: the power to request provides them with the benefit of improved compliance with imperfect duties, while granting requesters control over their

¹For simplicity, I generally restrict attention to requests on one's own behalf.

dependence on others and associated reasons of reciprocity. But there is also value for requestees: by helping them to live up to their imperfect duties, the power to request improves requestees' relationships with beneficiaries of imperfect duties. These values for requesters and requestees justify the Imperfect Duty Account.² I will first explain imperfect duties and then explain the account.

Imperfect duties are simply duties that grant us significant discretion to decide exactly when and how to comply.³ Such duties are a basic feature of both common-sense morality and non-consequentialist moral theorizing. Consider our imperfect duties to express kindness to strangers, to perform community service, to respect nature, to donate to charities, to engage in civic discourse, to develop and share our talents, and to exercise due care (Herman, 2021, Ch. 3). Each of us enjoys some discretion in deciding exactly when and how we will live up to these duties. Of course, almost any duty involves discretion, in the sense that there are multiple ways of fulfilling it: I can fulfill my promise to return your book using my right hand, or my left one (Stocker, 1967, pp. 507-11). But unlike most promissory obligations, imperfect duties grant us discretion in a deeper sense: the options they leave open differ significantly in the kinds and amounts of value that they realize (Wallace, 2019a, p. 51). I can be kind to strangers by cooking meals for a local shelter, or by advocating for safer street design after witnessing an accident, even when these acts differ significantly in the kinds and amounts of value that they realize.

The discretion associated with imperfect duties is valuable, because it lends expressive significance to compliance (Wallace, 2019a, p. 62), gives each of us some elbow room to pursue the projects and relationships that lend our lives meaning (Saunders et al., 2023, pp. 5-6), and appropriately registers that many of our duties apply to us as members of larger groups (Schroeder, 2014, pp. 17-25). For example, there is room for discretion

²This is a view of the value that justifies the power to request, which is largely neutral on what requests are and what they communicate. I discuss the latter in §1.1.

³This is a stipulative definition, not a substantive claim. Imperfect duties are sometimes instead defined in a more technical way, which ties them to Kantian views of morality (Rainbolt, 2000). Note that a utilitarian who denies that there are imperfect duties could happily accept the Imperfect Duty Account as an explanation of why requests do not create reasons.

in determining how one will donate to charities. This discretion grants our donations important expressive significance, given that there are a number of similarly effective charities addressing importantly different problems. This discretion also protects individuals' freedom to live their own lives, while appropriately registering that supporting the efforts of effective charities is a shared responsibility, not that of a lone individual (Dietz, 2019; Wallace, 2019a, pp. 63-4, 70).

However, the discretion associated with imperfect duties makes them deliberately inconclusive: there is usually no decisive rational pressure to comply in any particular case. This leads to a *deliberative problem*: imperfect duties provide us with little deliberative guidance, since they standardly do not require any particular act at any particular time. If you see a stranger looking confusedly at a map in the subway, you can comply with the imperfect duty of mutual aid by offering your help. But you can also refrain from helping, and instead help out another stranger later.

This in turn creates a *motivational problem*: compliance with imperfect duties is both optional and burdensome, so we are liable in each case to defer compliance to a later time. In short, the deliberative inconclusiveness of imperfect duties makes us liable to systematically fall short of them (Scheffler 2010, pp. 292-4; see also Tenenbaum and Raffman 2012, pp. 99-100). This motivational problem is a moral hazard. By reducing compliance, it harms potential beneficiaries of imperfect duties, and it thereby worsens the relationship between these beneficiaries and those who fall short of their imperfect duties. As I'll now explain, requests mitigate this motivational problem by mitigating the deliberative problem that causes it.

Imperfect duties provide reasons for conformity in each case, but they are reasons that the agent standardly has the discretion to set aside. Action on the basis of these reasons is not required, even when there are no countervailing considerations.⁴ By contrast, the

⁴I remain neutral here on when exactly this discretion arises. Raz (1999) argues that it arises when the relevant options are of incommensurable value. Gert (2003) argues that discretion arises when reasons justify these options without requiring them. Portmore (2012) argues that it arises when different options

reason provided by a request plays a non-optional role in deliberation, by *weighing in favor of a requirement* to do what is requested: if this reason is the only consideration in play, you should respond to it by doing the act it favors. In other words, in particular cases, imperfect duties standardly provide *justifying* reasons, which weigh in favor of an action's permissibility, and which an agent enjoys the discretion to set aside, even when there are no countervailing considerations. By contrast, requests create *pro tanto requiring* reasons, which weigh in favor of a requirement to do an action, making the action required if there are no countervailing considerations.⁵

Because they weigh in favor of requirements to do what is requested, the reasons created by requests mitigate the deliberative problem associated with our imperfect duties. When a request is made, the question of whether to comply with the imperfect duty no longer depends purely on the agent's discretion and the content of the duty, which might not require any particular act at any particular time. Instead, compliance now depends on whether the reason provided by the request is stronger than the other reasons in play. Even if the reason is outweighed, it anchors deliberation: it must be outweighed by con-

fit into larger courses of action which equally achieve the same valuable end.

⁵I thus depart from Enoch (2011), who says that a request does not partly constitute the reason for granting it, and from Owens (2012, pp. 85-87, 98-100, 117, 228-9), who suggests at times that requests provide merely justifying reasons. Requests create *pro tanto* requiring reasons. They do not necessarily create directed duties, and thus do not in general transform antecedent imperfect duties into perfect ones. The distinction between justifying and requiring reasons was developed by Gert (2003, 2004, 2005, 2007) and by Tucker (2022ba; 2022ab; 2023, 2025ba). According to a recent literature review, the distinction is "standard" and has been widely applied in practical ethics, for example in explanations of supererogation, the relationship between moral and rational requirements, and prohibition dilemmas (Tucker 2025ab, §3.3). This sort of distinction is pervasive—compare, for example, Kagan's (1989) distinction between "insistent" and "noninsistent" reasons (which reappears in Kolodny 2003), Dancy (2004) on "enticing" reasons, Greenspan (2005) on "purely positive" reasons, Horgan and Timmons (2010, p. 49) on "merit-conferring" reasons, discussions of "commendatory" reasons (Little 2013; Little & Macnamara 2020, 2017, 2022), and Scanlon (2014, p. 107) on "strongly optional" reasons.

One might wonder whether, once a request is made, the reason provided by the antecedent imperfect duty disappears. I think it does not. If a friend asks for help moving and I agree, I may be moved directly by the idea that it will make them feel supported, or by the simple thought that "this is the kind of thing friends do for each other"—a thought which, I assume, refers indirectly to imperfect duties among friends. These reasons are available to me after the request, but the request also makes available a distinct motive: I can help my friend "because they asked" (Owens, 2012, p. 86, McMyler, 2017, p. 79, Gläser, 2019, p. 29). This suggests that requests leave antecedent reasons in place. But if the reader disagrees, they are free to adjust the Imperfect Duty Account accordingly: requests would then disable the justifying reasons provided by imperfect duties while replacing them with new, requiring reasons, or else convert these justifying reasons into requiring reasons.

siderations applying to this particular case. The requestee cannot simply cite their generic interest in discretion to defer compliance with imperfect duties, but must have a reason to exercise that discretion on this occasion. In these ways, the reason provided by a request simplifies deliberation about imperfect duties, thereby mitigating the deliberative problem.

As a result, the reason created by a request also mitigates the motivational problem: when an agent's reasons not to comply in a particular case are less weighty than the reason created by the request, there is a perfectly clear motivational route via this reason to the conclusion that they ought to comply. The requestee would wrong the requester by ignoring the request and the reason it creates (Goldberg, 2020). By mitigating the deliberative and motivational problems associated with imperfect duties, requests improve compliance with imperfect duties. This is mainly valuable for requesters, since they are the beneficiaries of these duties. But it is also valuable for requestees, who otherwise would have fallen short of their imperfect duties: we have an interest in living up to our duties, since falling short of them worsens our relations to others (Scanlon 1998, Ch. 4; Wallace, 2019b, pp. 62, 94–5, 141–5, 163–4, 187, 246n64).

Notice that if a request merely communicated the existence of an imperfect duty without creating a reason, it would not address the relevant deliberative or motivational problems: it would just remind the requestee of them. Thus my view is incompatible with what I will call *Epistemicism*, the view that requests do not create new reasons in any systematic way, but rather call attention to reasons that exist already (Laskowski and Silver, 2021, pp. 61–2; Weltman, 2022a, 2022b, 2023).⁶

Precisely because requests create reasons by *mitigating* (and not merely re-introducing) the deliberative and motivational problems, my view correctly implies that self-requests do not create reasons. Indeed, if self-requests created reasons, they would not mitigate

⁶On the objection that Epistemicism cannot explain why it is felicitous (e.g.) to tell a friend that one wants help moving but won't ask for it, see Schaber (2021, pp. 434, 463–4) and Weltman (2022b, pp. 1733–6; 2023, pp. 398–9). On the objection that Epistemicism cannot make sense of efforts to avoid a request, see Weltman (2022a).

the relevant deliberative and motivational problems, but only push them one step back. Instead of “Shall I comply with my imperfect duty?”, the agent would face the question, “Shall I request compliance of myself?”. The same deliberative and motivational problems would persist, since the agent has the discretion to choose whether they issue a request, and would be correspondingly liable to defer the self-request (and compliance) for later. Self-requests do not create reasons, because like a reminder of an antecedent imperfect duty, they would not thereby mitigate the relevant problems.

To be sure, there are other possible means of mitigating the deliberative and motivational problems associated with imperfect duties. Perhaps you have special reasons to help intimates or those who are regularly in close proximity to you. These reasons mitigate the relevant problems, but the solutions they provide are costly: if a beneficiary of an imperfect duty is in need, they cannot always go out and make some new friends, or keep themselves near to someone who can help. Requesting is often easier: you just say a few words. In addition, as I now explain, requests have a special advantage over these alternative solutions: requests provide beneficiaries of imperfect duties with a means of controlling, on a case-by-case basis, who will help them.⁷

Receiving someone’s help is a way of depending on them. Because this relationship of dependence creates reasons of reciprocity and can affect a person’s ability to see themselves as autonomous (Herman, 2012, p. 406, 2021, pp. 18-22), we have an interest in deciding when and whether we enter into it. The normative power of requesting answers this interest: because a normative power is an ability to control a normative condition at will, the normative power of requesting makes our dependence on others contingent on our will (and their willing acceptance of our request).

In particular, requesters can control *exactly who* will help them, and *exactly how* they will receive help: rather than waiting for the right person to offer the right kind of help, requesters can simply choose to give reasons for specific actions to the particular person

⁷Compare Viehoff’s (2025a) suggestion that commands provide a low-cost means of controlling the addressees’ actions.

they feel comfortable relying on. For example, the stranger lost in the subway can ask for help from someone who looks friendly, or who seems not to be in a rush, or who reminds them of their sibling. Thus while there are many ways of mitigating the relevant deliberative and motivational problems, requests mitigate these problems in a special way: they let requesters choose particular people to perform particular actions, granting them costless and fine-grained control over their relationships of dependence and associated reasons of reciprocity.⁸

This concludes my statement of the Imperfect Duty Account. To recap: imperfect duties come with a motivational problem, which is a moral hazard, since it harms potential beneficiaries of imperfect duties and thereby worsens their relations with those who fall short of imperfect duties. Requests mitigate this motivational problem by mitigating the deliberative problem that creates it. Further, requests mitigate these problems in a distinctive way, namely by granting requesters costless and fine-grained control over who will help them and exactly how they will receive help.

One might question whether it is really a problem that our imperfect duties are deliberatively inconclusive. It is *valuable* for people to be uncertain about their imperfect duties, and for people to take responsibility for living up to them without the prompting or guidance of others. Deliberative inconclusiveness is not a problem to be mitigated: it just reflects our discretion, which is part of the point of imperfect duties.

However, it is one thing to say that the discretion of imperfect duties is valuable, and another to say that it does not introduce moral hazards which can be mitigated by requests. It is crucial that requests mitigate these hazards while respecting the valuable discretion associated with imperfect duties. The requestee remains free to decline the

⁸Cupit's (1994) view of requests appeals to reciprocity in a different way. According to Cupit, a request creates a reason because we have reasons of reciprocity not to disappoint others by betraying the trust they place in us by requesting. I won't press the point, but it is worth flagging a circularity concern. On this view, requests create reasons to avoid the disappointment that comes with not granting them. But the relevant reason is a reason to regret having been a *fitting* disappointment to another, and perhaps disappointment is fitting only when the requester had the standing to request, and thus to create a reason by requesting. For discussion of an analogous circularity worry for assurance-based accounts of promissory obligation, see Scanlon (1998, pp. 307-8) and Kolodny and Wallace (2003, pp. 131-6).

request by citing a reason for exercising their discretion on this particular occasion. And if the reason created by the request is not weighty enough to tip the scales in favor of the act requested, the requestee retains full discretion to decide how they will comply with the relevant duty.

To further clarify the Imperfect Duty Account, I'll first circumscribe the requests it is meant to explain and then contrast it with Raz's view of commands and with an alternative view of how requests create reasons.

1.1 Two Kinds of Requests

Many requests are difficult to distinguish from commands, demands, or expressions of desires. When your boss asks for a report, they are issuing a polite *command*. When a swimmer asks a lifeguard to save their drowning friend, they are issuing a *demand*, by informing the lifeguard of a duty of rescue. When a friend says that they would love some chocolate, they might be merely *expressing a desire*. Such cases suggest that requests do not exercise normative powers or do not exercise them in a distinctive way.

To make sense of such cases, we need to distinguish wide and narrow senses of requesting. When a surgeon says to an assistant "Give me a scalpel, please," they issue a command, but it would be perfectly felicitous to describe the situation by saying that the surgeon asked for a scalpel, or indeed that they requested it. We often use "requesting" in a *wide* sense to refer to any act that can be described as asking. In this sense, many commands, demands, entreaties, pleas, exhortations, invitations, and expressions of wishes or desires would also count as requests.

That said, we are often careful to distinguish requests from these other kinds of acts, as when someone says that they are not *telling* you to do something, but rather *merely asking* you to do it. My claim is that requesting in this *narrower* sense can be distinguished from other kinds of asking in terms of a normative power to create reasons. The swimmer who asks the lifeguard to save their drowning friend is requesting in the wide sense, but not

in the narrow sense; they are issuing a politely phrased demand.

The Imperfect Duty Account is neutral on what, if anything, unifies requests in the wide sense. Some acts which are only requests in the wide sense might motivate the view I called Epistemicism about requests, on which requests merely communicate prior reasons (Weltman 2022b, pp. 1715-7). Alternatively, requests might be proposals in joint practical deliberation (de Kenessey, 2022, pp. 892, 895–9), just as assertions are proposals to update the common ground of a conversation (Stalnaker, 1987). Or perhaps requests simply express the requesters' desire that another be motivated to some degree to do an act (Searle, 1969, pp. 62, 66). Some linguists hold, relatedly, that a request is an utterance with directive force, which communicates content that is not ruled in or out by the common ground (Ruytenbeek et al., 2017, p. 47).⁹

However, these views do not straightforwardly distinguish requests from commands, demands, entreaties, pleas, exhortations, invitations, or expressions of wishes or desires. The appeal to normative powers is explanatorily powerful, because it ties together requests in the more narrow sense, by citing a value that explains how they create reasons.

I thus accept the claim that requesting in the narrow sense is a normative power—an ability to control a normative condition at will—and that this power is justified by its value. In particular, as I explain in the last section of the paper, I propose that the reason created by a request enjoys a “two-tier” justification (Kolodny, 2025, p. 645): this

⁹This content is explicitly introduced by direct requests, which are typically imperatives, deontically modalized declaratives, or performative clauses (Ruytenbeek, 2019, pp. 46-7), e.g. “Close the window,” “You must/have to close the window,” or “I’m asking you to close the window.” Indirect requests instead communicate this content by implicature (Ruytenbeek, 2019, pp. 79-82). Among indirect requests, theorists further distinguish “on the record” and “off the record” requests (Blum-Kulka, 1987, pp. 141-2). On the record indirect requests are often modal interrogatives and make the speaker responsible for their request (Blum-Kulka, 1987, p. 140), in the sense that they cannot plausibly deny having issued a request (Camp, 2018, pp. 47-52). For example (Aikhenvald, 2010, p. 258): “Can/can’t/could/couldn’t you close the window?”, “Is it possible to close the window?”, “Will/won’t/would/wouldn’t you (mind/like to/care to/be so kind as to) close the window?”, “Must you leave the window open?”. Off the record indirect requests are typically declaratives that indicate the speaker’s preferences about the situation or the very act of requesting (Macaulay, 1996), or so-called “suggestory requests” (Blum-Kulka, 1987, p. 133): “It’s cold in here.”, “If you could close the window, I’d be very grateful.”, “I wonder whether you would mind closing the window.”, “I’d like to ask you to close the window.”, “How about closing the window?”, “Why not close the window?”, “Why don’t you close the window?”

reason is explained by the power to create a reason by requesting, and this power is explained by the value of requesting as a social practice. However, I want to be clear that I reject some controversial claims that are often associated with the view that requesting is a normative power. It is often claimed that the value that explains normative powers is non-instrumental (Owens, 2012, Ch. 1), or that it attaches to their possession as such (Raz, 2022, pp. 175-6, Bruno, 2022, p. 3222). I will not invoke these claims, which are sometimes rejected as mysterious or unexplanatory (Wallace, 2019b, pp. 165-7). Normative powers can be justified by their instrumental value. That is, it might be valuable for me to be able to create reasons for you, not because this control over your *normative situation* is valuable to me *in itself*, but because the resulting control over *your deliberation and action* is a generally effective means to *other values*, like autonomy or friendship (Viehoff, 2025b). On one view, this further value is desire-satisfaction: the practice of requesting is valuable insofar as it helps people to get what they have reason to want (Schaber, 2021, pp. 434-7). However, there is good reason to be skeptical that we have reasons to satisfy others' rational desires, whatever they happen to be (e.g., Darwall, 2001, pp. 136-9). I propose instead that requests create reasons because they thereby mitigate deliberative and motivational problems associated with our imperfect duties, while granting requesters control over their dependence on others and associated reasons of reciprocity.

1.2 Requests and Commands

It is natural enough to suggest that requests are distinguished from commands by the fact that the reasons created by requests are discretionary. But what does this suggestion amount to? Requests are sometimes said to be discretionary insofar as they create mere pro tanto reasons, which do not ground obligations (Raz, 2009, pp. 14-5; Lance and Kukla, 2013, p. 460; Lewis, 2018, p. 11). But authoritative commands can sometimes be overridden by other considerations, and sincere requests often create obligations, as when a friend asks for your help moving, and you could easily assist them. Indeed,

on some views, requests *generally* create obligations (Cupit, 1994, Gläser, 2019, pp. 33-5, Khokhar, 2022, pp. 8-10). Alternatively, some propose that the reasons created by requests are discretionary insofar as we have the discretion to choose whom to value as an intimate, and requests among intimates create reasons only because intimates value each other (Lewis, 2018, pp. 12-14). But as I'll later explain, I want to make room for the idea that requests can create reasons among perfect strangers, who share no concrete, particular valuable relationships.

The appeal to imperfect duties provides a distinct, complementary explanation. The reason created by a request is partly explained by an antecedent imperfect duty, which grants the requestee a degree of discretion in deciding how to live up to it. Although this reason weighs in favor of a requirement to do the act requested, the requestee remains free to cite particular countervailing considerations. And if the reason provided by the request is outweighed, the requestee retains their discretion to decide how to comply with the relevant imperfect duty. In all of these ways, the reason created by a request is discretionary.

To illustrate the contrast with commands, consider Raz's (1988) *Service Conception* of authority, on which an addressee has a defeasible duty to comply with an authority's justified command, because in accepting that they have such a duty, the addressee would generally comply better with reasons that apply to them independently. A justified command will provide decisive judgment on a range of practical reasons, for example relating to study habits, finance, or emergency preparedness. By providing a summary judgment of these reasons, a command delivers a verdict regarding what the addressee should do, which is meant to pre-empt the addressee's own judgment (Raz, 1988, pp. 57-62).¹⁰

By contrast, in applying an antecedent imperfect duty to the case at hand, a request need only provide the addressee with a reason, because requests and commands address distinct deliberative problems. Whereas commands aim to settle the deliberative ques-

¹⁰Raz (1988, pp. 48-51) proposes that it is valuable for commands to summarize reasons because they thereby break ties among reasons and resolve prisoner's dilemmas and coordination problems.

tion of what to do with respect to a range of reasons, requests merely lend deliberative clarity to an otherwise inconclusive imperfect duty, and need not thereby pre-empt the addressee's own judgment about the other reasons in play. In a slogan: whereas commands create duties by summarizing antecedent reasons, requests create reasons by specifying antecedent duties.

My view of requests dovetails with Raz's account of commands, suggesting a unified view of these normative powers: requests and commands work by mitigating the deliberative problems posed by antecedent considerations. However, there are two important differences between Raz's view of commands and my view of requests. First, Raz believes that the power to command is justified primarily by its deliberative value for the *addressee*: it exists only because the addressee will comply better with their independent reasons by treating such commands as authoritative. By contrast, the power to request is mainly justified by its value for *those who wield it*: requests give requesters the benefits of improved compliance with imperfect duties, while granting them control over their dependence on others and associated reasons of reciprocity.

Second, for Raz, the antecedent considerations summarized by a command are simply reasons, which are not necessarily tied to any (e.g. democratic) relationship between the commander and their subjects. This leads to a worry that Raz implausibly bestows legitimacy on deeply unjust *de facto* authorities (Christiano, 2004, p. 278; cf. Estlund, 2007, p. 118). As Christiano says, if an evil authoritarian ruler commands George to run a chemical weapons factory, and George knows that by taking on the job, he could surreptitiously slow the development of weapons that would harm innocent people, then the ruler's command may create a duty for George, according to the Service Conception. For we can suppose that George would better comply with the reasons applying to him by treating the ruler's commands as authoritative. Nonetheless, since the ruler is an evil despot, his authority should not count as legitimate—he has no right to control others' actions in the way that he does.

On one way of elaborating this worry, Raz's view cannot explain legitimate authority, because it does not sufficiently constrain the relationship between the issuer and recipient of the command. The view I favor does not face an analogous worry, because the antecedent consideration specified by a request is not a set of reasons unrelated to the requester and requestee, but rather an imperfect duty, which constitutes a normative relationship between the requester and requestee.¹¹

1.3 Requests and Relationships

According to *the Relationship View*, requests create reasons by way of the value that requesters and requestees place in their relationship (Lewis, 2018). Accounts of how requests create reasons often focus exclusively on requests when the prospect of a valuable intimate relation or interaction is available (Owens, 2012, p. 161; Lewis, 2018; Khokhar, 2022). On one way of elaborating this view, requests among strangers merely communicate the existence of pre-existing reasons (cf. Schaber, 2021, p. 436).

A comprehensive assessment of the Relationship View lies beyond the scope of this paper, but here are two reservations I have about the idea that requests only create reasons by way of the value of concrete, particular relationships. First, requests among strangers really do seem to create reasons—consider a stranger asking that you give them directions, lend them your phone to make a call, take their photo, let them pet your dog, or share your table in a crowded coffee shop. Such requests create reasons, even if the stranger is not your neighbor, your fellow citizen, or related to you in any other particu-

¹¹A single directive might simultaneously create a duty in the way described by the Service Conception and create a reason in the way described by the Imperfect Duty Account. For example, perhaps when a state directs its citizens to pay taxes, it thereby summarizes antecedent reasons applying to them, while also helping citizens to better comply with an imperfect duty of charity towards fellow citizens. Some object that Raz's view cannot make sense of cases in which an authority's directive is binding, even though they are mistaken (cf. Tadros, 2020, p. 76). A similar worry applies to the Imperfect Duty Account: if a neighbor mistakenly believes that you borrowed their ladder last month and asks you to help them move a heavy table in turn, perhaps their request creates a reason, even though they are mistaken about the antecedent imperfect duty of gratitude. One response appeals to uncertainty: an addressee is not always in a position to know whether the addressor is mistaken; perhaps lifting the table falls under a duty of mutual aid, if not one of gratitude. For discussion, see Viehoff (2025a).

lar way.

In response to such cases, one might say that *simply by issuing a request*, the requester creates a valuable relationship of trust. The requester trusts the requestee to give their request due consideration, and the value of this relationship of trust would then create a reason to grant the request. But this seems to me to stretch the notion of a valuable relationship beyond its natural limits. It also gets the order of explanation the wrong way around. We trust that others will respond to the reasons created by our requests: the reasons explain our trust. So this trust is not well-positioned to explain the reasons created by requests, on pain of circularity.

Second, the appeal to the value of relationships does not explain how exactly we get from the value of a relationship to our reasons to grant particular requests. What criterion distinguishes the requests that create reasons from the ones that don't? Consider a friend's request that you poke someone or do a little dance for their entertainment. (Or recall the requests for murder or for a distant toothbrush from the introduction.) Such requests do not create reasons, even if they occur against the backdrop of a valuable relationship. The appeal to imperfect duties nicely explains this, but the Relationship View is less predictive.¹²

It is striking that sincere requests seem to track imperfect duties. A stranger's request for your charitable donation calls on an imperfect duty of charity, and a friend's request for help moving calls on a duty of mutual aid. Without elaboration, the Relationship View leaves it mysterious why requests among strangers and intimates alike should track imperfect duties in these ways. By contrast, on my view, requests create reasons among strangers and intimates in the same way, namely by mitigating deliberative and motivational problems associated with our imperfect duties. However, we have more (and more

¹²For example, Lewis (2018, p. 18) says that "Person A has a reason to ϕ if requested to do so by Person B and if Person A places sufficient discretionary value in Person B," where to place discretionary value in a person is (roughly) to stand in a discretionary valuable relationship with that person and to value that person as a member of that relationship. This view places no constraints on ϕ : on this view, *any* action requested in the context of a valuable relationship creates a reason.

demanding) imperfect duties with respect to our intimates than we do with respect to strangers. For this reason, we can ask more of intimates than we can of strangers.

2 Asking Too Much

Now, I'll address the concern that the Imperfect Duty Account licenses too many requests. We can distinguish three ways of spelling out this concern.¹³ First, it might be objected that this account implies that any potential beneficiary of an imperfect duty can create a reason by requesting any act that counts towards its satisfaction. This implication would be implausible: if someone asks that you risk your life to save a child from an oncoming train, or that you dedicate your career to humanitarian work, they do not seem to create a new reason for you to do so.

In reply: even if an act *counts toward* the satisfaction of an imperfect duty, in the sense that doing the act now would grant the agent greater discretion not to comply with the duty later, the act in question is not necessarily *required* by this duty. Indeed, the act might be supererogatory. Supererogatory acts often express good will towards others, and thereby count towards the satisfaction of an imperfect duty of kindness, mutual aid, or beneficence. (If you jump onto the tracks to save a child, perhaps you've done your fair share of kindness to strangers for the day.) But supererogatory acts do not always fall within the scope of what these duties require, so requests for these acts need not create reasons.¹⁴

¹³My view implies that requests for wrong acts can create reasons only if (somehow) such acts fall under imperfect duties. Here is a possible case with this structure. Assume you have a conditional obligation: you are not required to help either A or B to carry their bags, but if you help one of them, you should help B, e.g. because A is only struggling to carry two bags, and B is struggling to carry five of them. Then helping A is wrong. But perhaps if A requests help, this request creates a reason. Regarding the analogous view of promising, on which promises to do what is independently wrongful may nonetheless be binding, see Shiffrin (2011) and Owens (2016).

¹⁴The scope of our power to request depends on the scope of our imperfect duties. If we have a general imperfect duty to do favors (Benziman, 2023, pp. 302-5; cf. Scanlon, 2008, Ch. 3), or if all supererogatory acts fall under imperfect duties (Hale, 1991), many potential beneficiaries will possess the power to create reasons by requesting. Otherwise, the power to create reasons by requesting is more limited.

Second, it might be objected that even requests for acts that are *required* by imperfect duties can fail to create reasons. Suppose a stranger requests that you spend five minutes looking for trash on your next hike. Even if this act falls under an imperfect duty of respect for nature, it seems odd to say that this request creates a reason.

In reply: our duty to respect nature might not be owed to anyone, or owed only to ourselves. The Imperfect Duty Account applies only when the requester's interests partly explain why there is an imperfect duty to perform acts of the kind requested. If our duty to respect nature is not explained by individuals' interests, but rather by the impersonal value of nature, then my account implies that requests for compliance with this duty do not create reasons.¹⁵

Finally, it could be argued that the Imperfect Duty Account is too permissive in a different way: it might license unfair requests. If the power to request is unfair and thus highly disvaluable, and normative powers are justified by their value, this poses a problem for the idea that requests exercise a normative power.

It may seem unfair that requests create reasons, because *morally arbitrary factors*, like personality quirks, influence who issues requests and who accepts them. But even if a fact is morally arbitrary, in the sense that there is no moral reason that explains why it is true, it does not follow that the fact is morally arbitrary in the further sense that it is morally irrelevant to what one ought to do (Nozick, 1974, pp. 213-6). For example, the intimate relations that give us special reasons to care for those dear to us are largely arbitrary: they are explained by causal laws, not moral ones. But it does not follow that our intimate relations are morally irrelevant to what we ought to do. Quirks of personality influence who issues or accepts requests, but it does not follow that requests are irrelevant to what we ought to do. After all, personality quirks also influence who makes or

¹⁵One might argue that imperfect duties in general are owed to no one and thus come with a problem of *accountability*, which requests mitigate by creating reasons. I do not make this argument, because imperfect duties might be modeled as duties to do one's fair share, owed directly to each potential beneficiary (Murphy, 2000; Wallace, 2019a), and because requests might not always create the directed duties that are thought by some to underlie relations of interpersonal accountability (Darwall, 2006; Wallace, 2019b).

accepts promises, but it does not follow that promises are irrelevant to what we ought to do.

Still, one might worry that on the Imperfect Duty Account, there is a risk that requests will create an unfair division of benefits and burdens among those who are subject to imperfect duties and among those who stand to benefit from compliance with them. After all, as *someone subject* to imperfect duties, you might have more reasons to comply, just because people feel inclined to issue requests to you. And as a *potential beneficiary* of imperfect duties, by requesting excessively from others, you might direct to yourself more than your fair share of compliance with imperfect duties. I'll address each worry in turn.

It is unfair that people are burdened by the reasons created by excessive requests, but this is a datum for a theory of requests to accommodate, not something to be explained away. When a couple's children almost always request help from their mother rather than their father, or when students more often request emotional support from teachers who are women, these requests create an unfairly gendered division of labor. Those who are unfairly overburdened in such cases are overburdened not just because they experience social pressure to help others, but also because they are inundated with genuine reasons to help others. The unfairness consists partly in the reasons created by the requests, which lead to an unfair division of labor with respect to the fulfillment of imperfect duties. If we were to deny that requests create reasons in such cases, we would be left unable to fully explain what is unfair about them.

This is not to say that there is nothing to be done about the unfair division of labor. On the contrary, a father has independent reasons to help his children, and these are intensified by the fact that helping would relieve a burden unfairly placed on the mother. Further, when a request is addressed to a whole group of requestees—two parents, for example—each requestee should take due care to ensure that the responsibility of granting the request does not unfairly overburden the other requestees.

Three devices mitigate unfairness in the distribution of benefits among requesters.¹⁶ First, by unfairly requesting, a requester may give others permission to disregard their requests (Herstein, 2017). Suppose a friend repeatedly asks for and receives your help, while passing up several clear opportunities to reciprocate. Or suppose that a student has a history of requesting additional help, with the result that they have received much more support than other, equally needy students. In such cases, the requester may give their requestee the standing to disregard their requests.

Second, for certain imperfect duties, there may be strong reasons to adopt a standing policy regarding compliance, which will spread benefits fairly and address the relevant deliberative problem. If an individual has adopted such a well-justified policy, a request that calls on the relevant imperfect duty might not further mitigate the associated deliberative problem, and would not in that case create a reason. For example, many adopt a policy of not giving money to those who stand outside of grocery stores to solicit donations for charities, electing instead to donate online after doing their own research. If a person has this policy, and it is justified, then that person's deliberative problem associated with charitable giving has been addressed, and strangers' in-person requests for donations will not create reasons. (If such a policy is not justified, the deliberative problem remains, and these requests do create reasons.)

Third and finally, when the stakes are high enough, the reason created by a request may simply be irrelevant. Suppose you can save Drew or Dorie from drowning but cannot save both of them, and that going into the water is dangerous enough to fall under an imperfect duty; you are not required to save either of them. Even if Drew's request that you save him creates a reason, the reason is too weak to be relevant to the decision of whom to save.¹⁷ More generally, sufficiently weak reasons are often irrelevant when lives

¹⁶Gläser (2019, p. 40) observes that two requests made in succession with identical content do not create two reasons. The Imperfect Duty Account nicely explains this: the first request already mitigated the deliberative problem, and there is no deliberative role left for the second, identical request.

¹⁷It may seem that any consideration should be able to break a tie (Rüger, 2020, p. 464). But while it may be permissible in a tie to choose *arbitrarily*, not just any reason is weighty enough to force the case one way

are at stake. If you learned that by saving Drew, you could also obtain ibuprofen that would cure Carl's sore throat, that would give you a further reason to save Drew, but the reason would be irrelevant to the question of what to do, given that there are lives at stake (Kamm, 2005). My view does not imply that in high stakes cases, ties can be broken by the reasons created by requests.¹⁸

Let me summarize the conclusions of this section. The Imperfect Duty Account does not imply that requests for supererogatory acts create reasons, and it is able to accommodate the observation that requests for compliance with imperfect duties (e.g. to respect nature) do not always create reasons. Although requests are sensitive to quirks of personality, it doesn't follow that requests are irrelevant to what we ought to do. The Imperfect Duty Account correctly predicts an unfair distribution of burdens among requestees. Three devices mitigate an unfair distribution of benefits among requesters, namely the permission to disregard particular requests, justified policies that address deliberative problems, and the fact that a reason created by a request may be irrelevant, given the stakes.

3 Asking Too Little

Even if the Imperfect Duty Account does not license too many requests, it might be thought to license too few of them. In particular, one might worry that my view fails to vindicate the reason-giving force of requests when they conflict, or when they are made without the context of an imperfect duty. I reply to each of these worries in turn.

or the other. A reason might not be weighty enough to disrupt parity between the options (Chang, 2017), and acting on it could deprive people of a fair chance to be saved (Bourguignon & Mossé, 2025).

¹⁸When the stakes are lower, requests can break the tie. Suppose two students equally deserve study help and only one of them requests it. If the other is not as comfortable making requests and has been systematically disadvantaged as a result, the students are not equally deserving after all. If instead they are equally comfortable making requests, one ought to help the student who requested.

3.1 Conflicting Requests

My view suggests that if many requests conflict, such that treating all of them as reasons would not mitigate the addressee's deliberative and motivational problems, these requests do not create reasons. As I'll now explain, this is the right result in some cases, but in other cases, it leads to a worry that my view fails to vindicate the reason-giving force of conflicting requests.

Suppose that with respect to his imperfect duty to support effective charities, Don faces the motivational and deliberative problems discussed earlier. Don could adopt a justified policy regarding compliance, which as we saw would mitigate his deliberative and motivational problems. But let us assume that he adopts no such policy, even after receiving other people's conflicting requests for donations. How should Don respond to these requests?

At one extreme, Don's mailbox might overflow with dozens of requests for substantial donations to effective charities, such that granting all of these requests would be supererogatory, going well beyond what Don's imperfect duties require. In that case, the requests do not mitigate Don's deliberative and motivational problems: they just reintroduce them. As a result, these requests would not create reasons, according to the Imperfect Duty Account.

This is the right result. Inundated with a flood of requests which simply enumerate the options for donations that he originally faced, Don would effectively be returned to the deliberative situation that he was in before receiving any requests. More generally, the strength of the reason created by a request is not the same in all cases (cf. Schaber, 2021, p. 438; Weltman, 2023, pp. 400-1). Instead, the strength of this reason depends on (a) the benefit to the requester, (b) the importance of the imperfect duty in question, and (c) the extent to which treating such requests as reasons would mitigate the requestee's deliberative and motivational problems. Thus if a requestee receives countless conflicting requests, which do not mitigate their deliberative and motivational problems much at all,

we should expect the resulting reasons to be very weak in strength, and at the extreme to disappear.

At the other extreme, Don might receive just two requests. First, Ben, a beneficiary of an effective charity, asks for Don's donation, and thereby creates a reason for Don to donate. Later, Don receives an additional request from Addie, a beneficiary of another charity. If donating to both Addie and Ben falls under Don's imperfect duty, then Don acquires reasons to make both donations. How can my view vindicate the reason-giving force of Addie's request, given that Ben's request already provided Don with deliberative guidance with respect to his imperfect duty of charity?

The answer is that Ben's request merely *mitigates* Don's deliberative and motivational problems, rather than solving them: it does not provide a complete solution to the deliberative question of how to comply with the imperfect duty of charity. Addie's request *further mitigates* Don's deliberative and motivational problems: if making both donations falls under Don's imperfect duty, and he can make both donations, then he complies better with his duty by treating both requests as reasons.

Alternatively, if budget constraints prevent Don from donating to both Addie and Ben, then Don's deliberative situation is worse in one way: he will have to adjudicate between Addie and Ben. But we should not exaggerate the difficulty of adjudicating between two requests. It may take some time to decide between Addie and Ben, but there are still significant deliberative benefits to Don. First, absent conflicting considerations, the requests collectively settle that Don is to donate now to either Addie or Ben. Second, in general, Don complies better with his imperfect duties if he treats each of a few competing requests as reasons, since he can comply with whichever reason is strongest. Ben's interests might be weightier than Addie's, so perhaps Don should help the person who requested first in this case. But in general, the first of a few competing requests might not be the most pressing. Don does better at helping others by taking each of a few requests into account as reasons. These requests create reasons on my account, by mitigating Don's

deliberative problems and thereby improving his compliance with his imperfect duties. These improvements result from just a few requests, but as we saw, they disappear when Don is overwhelmed with innumerable requests, which simply lay out the options he originally faced.

3.2 Requests without Imperfect Duties

Some requests seem to create reasons without invoking antecedent imperfect duties. Consider a mere acquaintance asking if you could look after their pet for a week, or a romantic partner asking if you would move with them to a new city.¹⁹ These requests create reasons, but the acts requested might not fall under imperfect duties. You have an imperfect duty to *friends* to do things like care for their pets, but perhaps such care falls outside of the scope of your imperfect duties to mere acquaintances. You have an imperfect duty to *long-term romantic partners* to adjust your life plans by doing things like moving with them, but perhaps moving falls outside of the scope of your imperfect duties to a romantic partner you've only been seeing for a month or two. These cases seem like counterexamples to the Imperfect Duty Account.

In reply, I am tempted to say that if each case is properly spelled out, and the request really does create a reason, we can cast about and find an imperfect duty. Perhaps too much weight is being put here on the distinction between acquaintances and friends, or between recent and long-term romantic partners. Or perhaps these distinctions track important distinctions in imperfect duties, but it only seems plausible that requests create reasons in these cases because we imagine that deeper relationships of friendship or long-term romantic partnership are already present.

But here is a more concessive reply. In both of these cases, a big ask is being made, and I imagine that these requests would be made with some hesitance or nervousness. One selling point of my view is that it makes sense of these requests as departures from the

¹⁹Thanks to Filippa Ronquist and Sophia Wyatt for pressing this worry.

paradigm case, where an imperfect duty is already in place: the requesters are stretching the boundaries of the power to request.²⁰ They are, in effect, *inviting* the requestee to deepen the relationship—from acquaintances to friends, or from recent to long-term partners—in a way that would *create* the relevant imperfect duties. The requestee has an opportunity to accept this invitation: by doing what is requested, they will not just better comply with an imperfect duty, but create it by developing the relationship. If you look after a mere acquaintance’s pet for a week, perhaps you are a step closer to friendship (or at least, a special relationship of reciprocal trust and support). If you move with a recent partner to a new city, perhaps you are deepening the commitment in your relationship. The requests in these cases should be thought of proleptically (Callard, 2016): they assume imperfect duties are in place as a way of inviting the requestee to take them on.

A maximally concessive reply would be that such cases show the need for *pluralism* about how requests create reasons: requests may create reasons in different ways in different contexts, and no one account may fit all the cases. I will leave open the possibility of pluralism, but I have indicated above some reservations about alternative views, like Epistemicism and the Relationship View, and I have argued that the Imperfect Duty Account has the resources to accommodate these cases.

4 Wishful Thinking and Advice

Having addressed some extensional worries, I will close the paper by addressing an intensional one. Normative powers invite a simple pattern of argument: if it would be valuable for us to possess a certain normative power, then we do possess it. But this seems mysterious, because analogous arguments involve fallacious wishful thinking. For example, it does not follow from the fact that it would be valuable for us to be able to fly like birds

²⁰Here I employ a common strategy: we often seek to understand a diverse phenomenon by accounting for paradigm cases, and then explaining other cases as departures from the paradigm (Fricker, 2016).

that we can (Enoch, 2009, Bruno, 2022, p. 3212).²¹

A full defense of the kind of wishful thinking licensed by value-based justifications of normative powers would require another paper, but here are two points that may help to de-mystify it. First, the effective exercise of the power to request requires some recognition on the part of those it is meant to affect. As a result, the justification for normative powers like requesting depends on the existence of actual social conventions, which make it possible for us to count on others to recognize our efforts to wield normative powers: it matters that as a matter of fact, we conventionally treat each other as creating reasons by requesting (Owens, 2012, pp. 9, 151). The idea behind normative powers is not that we should follow the rules of a purely imaginary social practice, which would be valuable if, contrary to fact, everyone did the same. Instead, the idea is that our actual social conventions, which treat requesters as wielding a power to create reasons, serve certain values, and that this explains why requests in fact create reasons.²²

Second, on my view, the power to request is justified by its value in general, rather than on each occasion of use. As a result, the proposed form of explanation parallels some familiar and widely-accepted patterns of justification. We often justify moral principles that assign rights to individuals by reflecting on the valuable status and relations that such rights would enable, were they generally accepted (Kamm, 1989, 1992; Quinn, 1998, pp. 309-12; Nagel, 1995, p. 92; Kumar, 1999, p. 305). In doing so, we are allowing the prospective value of a generally accepted system of moral principles to justify those

²¹It does not even seem to follow from the fact that it is *valuable for me to treat* a consideration as a reason that it *in fact* provides me with a reason. To amend Kavka's (1983) famous case, I could offer you \$100 to treat the fact that a toxin tastes terrible as a reason to drink it. It would then be monetarily valuable for you to treat the toxin's bad taste as a reason to drink it. But it wouldn't follow that the toxin's bad taste is itself a reason for you to drink it.

²²One might argue that if requesting is a social practice, then requests create reasons via the principle of fair play (Simmons, 1979): (a) if a practice is mutually beneficial and not unjust, (b) the benefits that come from it require that most of us cooperate, (c) cooperation is costly, and (d) one can receive benefits without cooperating, then anyone who accepts benefits of the practice should do their fair share. Perhaps doing our fair share in the practice of requesting involves treating others' requests as providing reasons. However, the principle of fair play struggles to explain the *directedness* of wrongs (Scanlon, 1998, p. 316; Kolodny and Wallace, 2003, pp. 125-6). In failing to treat another's request as providing you with a reason, you can wrong *them* in particular. But according to the principle of fair play, you take advantage of *everyone who contributes to the practice of requesting*, which may or may not include the requester.

principles. The justification for normative powers is another case of this familiar pattern of reasoning (Owens, 2012, p. 9; Bruno, 2022, p. 3225).

These points help me to explain the difference between requests and advice. At first blush, my view may seem to leave me unable to properly distinguish these. For if you were to treat others' advice as providing new reasons for you to do what they advise, you might thereby improve your compliance with imperfect duties. So it seems it would be valuable for us to treat advice as a source of reasons, in just the way that we treat requests as a source of reasons. Thus one might worry that my view implies, implausibly, that requests and advice both create reasons, and in the same way.

Requests differ from advice in two important respects, which correspond to the points above. First, I proposed that requests create reasons in part because we have widely accepted conventions, according to which requests are reason-giving: this paper is proposing a rationale for these conventions. There are no such conventions in the case of advice: we do not generally treat advice as a source of reasons, in the way that we do for requests. (If, contrary to fact, we did generally treat advice as a source of reasons, I would then say that we were treating advice-giving as a form of requesting.)²³

Second, I am proposing that the *practice of requesting as a whole* generally serves the value of improved compliance with imperfect duties. We give each other valuable advice about all sorts of things which do not fall under imperfect duties—for example, how to keep a promise, or how to appreciate a beautiful artwork. Unlike requests, advice does

²³The practice of requesting is highly conventional, and different societies differ greatly in the requests they consider acceptable, and in the particular forms of speech and action they count as requests. I am not proposing that these idiosyncratic conventions carve morality at its joints, but rather that the many social practices of requesting share a common function of improving compliance with imperfect duties, and that this explains why requests create reasons. Suppose, for example, that a society had a practice according to which if I wink at you and then nod my head at someone you are well-positioned to help, this creates a reason to help that person. If such a practice were not excessively unfair and improved compliance with imperfect duties, I would then say that the wink-and-nod practice is a practice of requesting, that it creates reasons, and that the force of these reasons is explained by imperfect duties. Conventions determine the form that requests take and which imperfect duties the practice of requesting supports (e.g. charity, mutual aid). Owens (2024, 2025) says that conventions determine whether requests create merely pro tanto reasons or obligations, but on my view, requests generally create pro tanto reasons. Owens (2022) argues that being bound by convention is valuable for its own sake, but on my view, the conventions of requesting are valuable insofar as they improve compliance with imperfect duties (§1.1).

not, in general, serve the value of improved compliance with imperfect duties. My view does not imply that *any particular act* creates a reason if treating it as a reason would improve compliance with an imperfect duty. If a form of second-personal address like requesting or advice-giving is going to create a reason *as such*, the justification for this claim should attach to that form of second-personal address generally, and not merely to particular instances of it.

Conclusion and Outlook

Requests exercise a remarkable normative power to create reasons. According to the Imperfect Duty Account, they do so because they thereby mitigate deliberative and motivational problems associated with our imperfect duties, while granting requesters control over their dependence on others and associated reasons of reciprocity. This view explains at once how requests create new reasons, why requesting is valuable, and how the reasons created by requests depend on antecedent considerations. I argued that this view also explains the sense in which the reasons created by requests are discretionary, gives a unified account of how requests create reasons among intimates and strangers, and reveals important forms of unfairness that result from requests. Further, my view leads to an illuminating contrast with Raz's (1988) view of commands: whereas commands create duties by summarizing antecedent reasons, requests create reasons by specifying antecedent duties. I also defended my view from the worries that it licenses too many requests or too few of them, and I addressed a worry that the justification for normative powers involves a fallacious form of wishful thinking. In developing my view, I brought out some additional selling points: my view explains why self-requests do not create reasons, provides an account of requests in the narrow sense, and appropriately distinguishes requests and advice.

I have focused on how requests create moral reasons. I leave open whether requests

can also create reasons that are not in any deep sense moral or second-personal (Darwall, 2006, Ch.1) but instead are simply practical reasons, no different in kind from prudential ones (Lewis, 2024). My view may be able to accommodate this possibility, since the discretion that gets the motivational problem (and thus my view) off the ground could arise in non-moral domains.

I restricted attention to requests on one's own behalf, but we can ask about the standing to request for others. Standing can be undercut by *complicity* or *hypocrisy*: if I fall short of an imperfect duty to you and make it more difficult for you to respond to it, I might thereby undermine my standing to request your compliance with the same duty to others. In such cases, even if I have the power to *act* for certain beneficiaries of imperfect duties as their fiduciary, I may yet lack the power to *request* on their behalf. The standing to request for others is also unavailable when requesting would be *meddlesome*: imagine a person asking a teacher to decorate their classroom more, when this person is a complete stranger with no relation to the teacher or any of their students. There are lively debates regarding acting for others (Viehoff, 2022) and regarding complicit, hypocritical, and meddlesome blame (Tognazzini & Coates, 2025), but the analogous issues regarding requests are comparatively under-explored.

There is, finally, the question of what we owe to those of whom we request. We may owe it to others not to issue a request when doing so would create an unfair division of labor in fulfilling imperfect duties, or would disrespect interests that justify the power to request (Khokhar, forthcoming), or would convey a lack of trust that another would help of their own accord (Laskowski & Silver, 2021). After a requestee has agreed to grant our request, we may owe it to them not to release them from the resulting duty, if they have already invested significant effort into doing what we asked (Passi, 2026). Finally, a request might wrong the requestee *by creating a reason*, since this puts the requestee in a double-bind: if they act as requested, they pay the practical cost of doing so, and if they do not, they pay a moral cost, in the form of a reason for regret (Mossé, 2026).

While I have indicated briefly how my account bears on these issues, my aim here has been to address the three questions I set out at the start, namely how requests create reasons, why requesting is valuable, and how the reasons created by requests depend on considerations that are already in play.²⁴

²⁴I am very grateful to anonymous referees, whose generous and detailed comments improved the paper substantially. For invaluable feedback and discussion, I would like to thank several people: Sarah Buss, Gabrielle Candès, Scott Casleton, Will Combs, Scott Cowan, Katie Coyne, Hannah DeBrine, William Dempsey, Hanika Froneman, Anhui Huang, Elise Johnston, Renée Jørgensen, Elek Lane, Russell McIntosh, Véronique Munoz-Dardé, Adrian Ommundsen, Filippa Ronquist, Edward Schwarz, Brenna Seiersen, Seana Shiffrin, Eric Swanson, Daniel Viehoff, Evelyn Wang, Eliza Wells, Daniel Weltman, and Seth Yalcin. Special thanks to my dissertation committee, Johann Frick, Anna Stilz, and R. Jay Wallace, for their guidance throughout.

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